

The Orthopedic Global Period Playbook

How unbundled post-op care triggers instant payer clawbacks.

The Global Trap: 90-day surgical packages bundle pre-op, intra-op, and post-op care into one single fee.

The 3 Global Modifiers

When and how to legally unbundle post-op encounters.

- **Modifier 58:** Staged or related procedure during the post-op period.
- **Modifier 78:** Unplanned return to OR for a related complication.
- **Modifier 79:** Unrelated procedure by the same surgeon during global period.

The E/M Exception: Modifier 24

Billing office visits during a 90-day global window.

- **Unrelated Diagnosis:** Primary ICD-10 must be entirely unrelated to surgical site.
- **Clear Header:** Clinical note must explicitly state care is distinct from surgery.
- **Zero Wound Checks:** If the note mentions checking the incision, payers bundle it.

Why Commercial Payers Scrutinize Modifiers

Automated pre-pay edits flag all surgical add-ons.

- **Pre-Payment Holds:** Payer algorithms hold claims pending operative reports.
- **Recoupment Demands:** Improperly appended -58/-78 triggers retrospective takebacks.
- **Deterministic Scrubbing:** Scrub against NCCI global days before clearinghouse drop.

Protect Your Surgical Margins

Benchmark your practice surgical denial and global period compliance.

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